Iphigenia in Orem
By Neil LaBute

YOUNG MAN:

I'll tell it once. One time because it deserves to be told, and then never again. Fair enough? So...where should I...let me see. Alright.

INTRODUCTION

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I never used to travel. Never cared much for driving all the time, meeting clients, that end of things...I mean, I did it when I first started, low man on the pole and whatever, but once I got the old MBA, foot in the door and all...I stuck to the desk as much as I could. I like it. That office...I don't know..."feel." The atmosphere. Faxes coming in, people zipping around, emergency strategy sessions, all that. It's like being a kid again, playing at "war" or that type of thing. You can just see what guys love about it. And I don't mean just guys either, because there's plenty of women in the field, too, obviously, but I mean "guys" like in...well, "guys." You know, how it's used these days. All encompassing. It's very high stakes, lots of cash floating around you, and the pressure's a real...well, just hot. Day in and day out. Seriously. It is. We may play it like a game sometimes, but believe me, a day doesn't go by in business that you're not out for somebody's blood.

I'll try and be...brief--things took a bit of a turn for us last year. My wife and me,

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the family, you know...we lost a child. Newborn. Well, five months old...just like that. Just happened. (BEAT) I was off that day, a Friday, I think, and Deborah, that's my wife, Deb, she was out--her mother was staying with us, and they were over at the safeway getting some milk--deb put the baby down, "Emma" we'd named her, she put Emma in our bed because that's where she'd been sleeping the first few months...we always thought that was a good bonding thing, I'd read it somewhere, or she heard it at relief society or something like that...anyway, so that's what she did. She tucks her in, and out they went. And see, I was gonna lie down with her, I really was, but I just went back to the living room for a second, watch a little wheel of fortune or something, you know, five minutes a week to myself. And I fell. Fell off to sleep right there, there on the loveseat by the window. (BEAT) Deb's mom...Emma's grandma...found her. Maybe a half hour later. She'd smothered herself under the covers, I don't know, beneath the weight of the comforter or whatever it was.

The little thing...died in our bed, tangling herself in the blankets. (BEAT) The police had to come, they do for any kind of infant death, that' what the officer said; I'd gotten a hold of myself by that time, still crying, but Deb...Deb was just kind of sitting there next to me, staring off, and this guy--this person-a detective, I suppose, was asking us questions. Standing there and firing off this series of questions. "Standard procedure," he assured us, but still...

PAUSE

What bothered him...no, "puzzled" him, he said, never came right out and said it bothered him but you could see by the way he...he didn't understand how the baby could get so far down. (BEAT) It seemed to him that the baby, a baby that young

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and small, was too far down toward the foot of the bed, and turned. Something about that seemed to be eating at him. I didn't understand what he was getting at, the way he kept going back and forth over the events and times and all that, "where were you standing?" and "approximately how long were you...?" blah blah blah. I mean, my god, we're sitting there on the edge of the sofa, the bed my daughter just died in I can see through an open door back down the hallway and this man is pacing around, sucking on the end of the chewed cap of a ballpoint pen and...asking me quietly, "did you check on her?" (BEAT) What's he getting at, anyway? I mean, that's a no-win, isn't it? Think about it...if I didn't check on her, I'm not a good father. And if I did go in there, if I had've done what I was supposed to do, had planned on doing, the nap...then maybe she'd be alive. (BEAT). And for just a second, just the briefest of moments...I catch Deb looking over at me. As if this is the first time the thought's come to her as well. This possibility. The whole incident hangs there--probably only two or three seconds all together--but it just lays there in the air over us all.

"Umm, no, I didn't. I meant to, but..." and off he goes. Says, "Fine." Stops me cold, and off he goes onto another tangent.

PAUSE

And finally they were gone. I looked around, and the front door slammed shut and it was empty. The house. They'd taken Emma out with them, the coroner, maybe a half hour before, wrapped in a little zip-up bag, something like what I carry my pressed shirts in when I travel. Emma was gone, and we ate dinner...we may have even ordered out that night; that probably sounds horrible, but Deb just couldn't stand over the stove right then, so it seems like we had pizza...and went to bed right after. (BEAT) The phone woke me about 11:30. I almost had to pry Deb's

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fingers off of mine to get it, but I was on by about the fourth ring. It was him. The police detective and very apologetic about calling so late, and the whole process and the usual stuff that you'd see on any of those cop programs on tv. (BEAT)

It'd all come out fine, he said, ruled "natural causes" after a few tests'd been run and he just wanted to let us know and if there was anything he could do he'd be glad to...I hung up without him finishing. He'd put us through enough that day. I hung up the receiver and just rolled back over to Deb. I just held her at first...putting my hand back in place and squeezing her fingers a bit. But it woke her. SHe woke up and we whispered to each other...talking under the sheet about things we hadn't mentioned in years! We were under the sheets, just them, because from that night on, Deb and I could never sleep with blankets on that bed again. (BEAT) Anyhow the talking must've gone on for hours, a few at least and then kissing and finally...we did what you'd imagine on a night like that, a moment when your entire universe has been changed forever. (BEAT) I don't know, but that may have even been the night that joe was...that's our youngest, "Joseph,"...so Joe came almost exactly nine months later. He's a great boy, he really is. ANd over time, with the new child...life goes on.

And that's what we did. We went on...and more than that. A lot more. But...all right. Ummm...there was a problem. That's what had started all this, I mean, originally. Started it all in motion...a problem at work. We'd been taken over recently, I mean, no big deal in theory, happened all the time, somebody else takes over, you lose a few of the stragglers, guys who couldn't keep up. (BEAT) So that was the story.

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Four of us were going to go, three of which I and everyone else had a pretty good idea of, three that should've gone a long time ago, but that last spot...that was the one. The tough call. There was me, who'd been steady and strong and average, you know, just average or slightly above, someone that they could count on, good sense of humor and everything for the past seven years. Well liked and I liked everyone. Or, most everyone. There was this woman, a few years younger than me and had come in during a wave of new hires about four years back...just plain vicious. We'd gotten off badly...actually I'd made a mistake once, a board meeting where I'd grouped her in with a "you guys oughta..." meaning that side of the table and she called me out on it. First meeting, maybe second she'd been to and she nails me out loud about my attitude, my limited "chauvinist lexicon" and all this other, just crap that she fired off. (BEAT) But she was one. Me, and her, because of the short time she'd been there, and a couple of other folks that had about the same seniority that I did...and that's what hung over our heads, each of us, day after day as we'd go into work.

I got the call just before Deb had gone to Safeway. Took it inthe den because it was coming from Chicago...friend of mine, at the home office, a guy from school actually, with a tip. A tip he'd heard that day and wanted to call me with it...it was me. I was the one that would make up the four, and he was so sorry and all that--he's a really good guy, I see him whenever I'm in Chicago, we were these really big jokers when we were at the "u" in the dorms together and so he was just doing what any guy would do, he said, letting me hear it from a friendly voiec, and giving me a jump, the weekend, anyway. Before he hung up he said again it was just what was going around, but he thought I should know...(BEAT)

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What was I gonna do? How could I possibly keep it all going, the lifestyle we'd made for ourselves, without my seniority, the benefit package...jobs all over being tight like they are? It just wouldn't be possible. (BEAT) It was like that moment in the film Kramer vs. Kramer, you know, where he decides he's got to get a job that day, right? I'm standing there, just taking in the DVD player, and our big screen tv, and one of the kids' bikes, I can see through the front window, the Land Rover, Wheel of Fortune's blasting on the TV in the family room...all these thoughts are swirling around in my head. And I hear it. (BEAT) I wasn't asleep...I couldn't have been, I mean I've tried to beleive it, make myself believe it, too, but I wasn't, or I never would've heard her. The baby, Emma, in the other room. As I was standing there I heard her cry out from inside the bedroom. I did...(BEAT) When I got to the doorway she was already under the blankets, she was, I swear, under them and fighting to get out. I rushed in there, to the edge of the carpet at the bedroom door and then, I don't know, something stopped me. Just stopped me like some invisible force had reached out and took hold of the back of my shirt and yanked me to a halt...I looked in at her again, this little yelp kind of coming up from her as she blundered around in there. This little...mound wandering around in there. It was nearly absurd, to walk in on something like this, I mean, you just could never be ready for a thing like this, and because of that, that specific part of it, the unreality...I was able to make the decision.

In that moment, standing there watching my daughter fight for her life, I made my decision. Well, when I looked at it, I mean, rationally, for even half-a-second there in the hallway, I realized that's what this was. An opportunity. And I wasn't going

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to waste it. (BEAT) So I--I'm just gonna say this, because it's a little...so. I went into the room and stood there by the bed, I stood there and pulled up the comforter by one corner and I saw her then. Her little fine sandy hair and her...I just kind of coaxed her down a bit. Down a bit further with the edge of my foot, turned her a touch and down and then I dropped the covers back and walked out...there was one last little sound Emma made, you could barely hear it. But I just kept walking, back out to the loveseat, there in the family room, and layed down and made myself go to sleep.

PAUSE

I kept my job. I did. And guess who was the one. I mean, after all that, guess who got it right between the eyes? (BEAT) I even walked her to the elevator the day she left, her and the other three, this was several months after all the other...I was right behind them with a "so long" and "we'll miss you" and right then, it came to me, it came to me with my friends standing around and that little...well, she wasn't looking so strong anymore, there in the open car, this box of stuff in her hands. As the doors were closing I said to them all, but staring straight at her, I said, "you guys take care now!" PAUSE

I was at a seminar, big yearly thing the company put on. This one was in Boston, six months back. My friend from Chicago flew in for it. Okay, so...after the morning session, just in passing as we were both in the restroom at one point, he said something to me, my friend, I guess trying to lighten things up a little, he mentioned work. And about the layoffs, and how glad I must've finally been to have

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gotten rid of you know who. And then he said, "Boy, I really had you going that Friday, didn't I?" I turned to him, standing there at the urinal, my fly still open and I turned to him and the whole picture was clear to me. Right then, it was as clear as a look in the future. What he'd done. What we always used to do to each other. See, he'd heard the real truth about what was coming and just couldn't let it go without a little razzing and so he'd given me the call, let me stew about it over the weekend. He was going to buzz me back Monday morning with the truth. But by then...

The point I want to make is that it didn't have to happen that way. I took this risk, this calculated risk for my family, that this whole episode would play out in our favor, give me that little edge at work and maybe things'd be okay, or they'd change their minds because of, you know... Who knows. It happened, and you go on. Like I said before, you just go on.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier – Dramatic Interp
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